

AI: The future is now

I Love English World 342, October 2021, 6min23s.

1. **When did the Go contest take place?** 1
⇒ 15 march 2016
2. **The Go contest was between...** 1
☐ two world's grand masters.
☒ a Go champion and an AI program.
☐ two AI programs named Lee Sedol and AlphaGo.
3. **Go is easier than chess.** 1
☐ True ☒ False
Justify your choice by quoting the document.
 ⇒ chess in comparison is child's play
4. **David Selinger...** 1
☐ is a Go champion.
☐ played against AlphaGo.
☒ is one of the creators of AlphaGo.
5. **What is the most impressive fact about AlphaGo?** 1
☐ It easily won the contest.
☒ Human programmers didn't teach it how to play.
☐ It played millions of games against thousands of humans.
6. **The Go tournament wasn't very popular in the West.** 1
 TRUE ☒ True ☐ False
Justify your choice by quoting the document.
 ⇒ hardly anyone followed the tournament in the west
7. **What is Xi Jinping's plan?** 1
☐ To beat AlphaGo by the year 2030.
☒ To lead his country to gain technological supremacy in AI.
☐ To demonstrate that AI can't outdo human intelligence and creativity.
8. **"Data is the new oil" means that our information...** 1
☐ is used by petroleum companies.
☐ costs a lot of money to companies.
☒ can yield a large profit to companies.
9. **Where is our information recorded?** 1
 ⇒
10. **How much of ebay's total data is the world's entire culture, research and books?**
☒ Under 50%.
☐ About 90%.
☐ 100%.
11. **People are aware of the value of their information.** 1

☒ True ☐ False

Justify your choice by quoting the document.

⇒ most of us typically do not care

12. **Why are the data farms and the servers permanently guarded?** 1

⇒ because our data is the key to AI

13. **By studying us, what are the AI computers trying to understand?** 1

Give two answers among several.

⇒ opinion

⇒ behaviour

14. **“The time that we are now living in is a crossroads for the human race” means that:**

☐ the human race is about to disappear. 1

☒ we have to choose wisely how we use technology.

☐ we will live in a golden era, no matter if we get it right or wrong with AI.

15. **AI has many more possibilities to offer than we imagine.** 1

☒ True ☐ False

Justify your choice by quoting the document.

⇒ AI has untold riches to offer us

16. **AI could lead a society to better results in terms of sustainability than humans.** 1

☒ True ☐ False

17. **What dystopian movies are mentioned in the document?** 1

⇒ Terminator

⇒ The hunger games

18. **What AI technology has already been used by militaries to track and kill people?** 1

⇒ AI drones

19. **In Chongqing, the police use AI ...** 1

☐ to verify the alibis of suspects.

☐ to track the Communist Party's opponents.

☒ to detect the emotions of random citizens.

20. **The story imagined by George Orwell in his book 1984 will never be a reality.** 1

☐ True ☒ False

Justify your choice by quoting the document.

⇒ but if we're not careful it could come to pass in 2024

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Artificial intelligence is no* science-fiction fantasy. Its many applications (from medical to military and social uses) are fast becoming a reality in our daily* lives. Here's how...

Part 1 The Game

The future began on 15 March, 2016. The occasion was a Go contest between one of the world's grand* masters, Lee Sedol, and an AI program called AlphaGo. Go is an ancient, and profoundly complex Chinese board* game. In fact, it has more possible configurations than there are atoms in the known universe. Chess*, in comparison, is child's* play.

"There is not a mathematically more complex problem that you can think about than Go," says David Selinger, one of the scientists behind AlphaGo.

Even* so, the significant* thing wasn't that AlphaGo easily won the contest. It was that AlphaGo was never* taught to play by human programmers.

AlphaGo learned by* itself, first by studying thousands of human games, then by playing millions of games on its own*.



MAN AGAINST THE MACHINE: meet the Chinese Go champion Ke Jie. In 2017, Jie played an AI program that had taught itself the complex game. But, like Go champion Lee Sedol before him, Jie lost!

Hardly* anyone followed the tournament in the West*, but it was watched by millions in China, including* President Xi Jinping.

WILL HUMANS BE OBSOLETE?

The result stunned* the country. The self-taught* machine not only played better than its human adversary, but it played with grace, imagination and extremely innovative tactics. It demonstrated that both human intelligence and creativity, in many domains,

may soon be outdone*. The following* year China's president, Xi Jinping, announced a highly ambitious national plan to become the world's dominant power in AI by the year 2030.

"This is a momentous* drive," says Dr Keyu Jin of the London School of Economics. "The nation has mobilised all national resources to gain* technological supremacy with an intensity unseen* since Chairman Mao's striving* to attain nuclear power."

Part 2

The Data

It is often said that “Data is the new oil”. This is why so many apps and internet services are free: what interests the companies is not our money, but information about our thoughts, interests and movements. When we pick up our telephone or use our computer, every detail is recorded in gigantic data farms.

And that immense mass of data is growing exponentially.

Already, it is estimated that an extraordinary 90 per cent of all the world’s information has been generated in the past two years. The entirety of humanity’s culture, research and writings, for example, is less than half the data that has been collected by eBay alone.

OUR DATA IS THE KEY TO AI

Most of us, typically, do not care. The information collected about us seems unimportant. Yet this information is so valuable that the data farms are guarded like gold depositories, with mobile

AI security guards on permanent patrol among the servers. Why? Because our data is the key to AI.

Just as AlphaGo was given thousands of Go games to study, the AI computers are using all of this data to study humans.

These AI computers are learning to comprehend us, both as groups and as individuals. This means understanding our opinions, our personalities, our behaviour and even our private, unspoken thoughts.

And not just those of the average person, you understand, but those of *you* personally.

Part 3

The Power

A leading authority on AI, Professor Stuart Russell of the University of California, Berkeley, says “the time that we are now living in is a crossroads for the human race. If we get it right it could be a golden era for humanity. We could abolish poverty and disease. If we get it wrong, we could create a technology-reinforced global dictatorship. We could even lose control over the world to our own technology.”

On the plus side, AI has untold riches to offer us. It is already revolutionising medicine and we are only seeing the tip of a very large iceberg [see p28]. On a social

level, a society partly organised by AI could be better and more sustainable than anything we as humans could ever achieve. And, as it improves, AI will even bring us emotional support [see p29].

A DREAM OR A DISASTER?

But it could also be a nightmare straight from movies such as *The Terminator* or *The Hunger Games*. Today, for example, there is a frantic AI arms race in progress and autonomous AI drones have already been used to track and kill individuals by world militaries. These are, in effect, terminators

[see p30]. Other AI nightmares already exist. In the “smart” city of Chongqing, in western China, facial-recognition cameras track citizens’ every movement. The police use emotional-analysis AI to detect when a suspect is lying or anxious, a computer score judging them guilty without evidence. This is the future facing most of China’s population under the Communist Party’s AI plan.

“I’m constantly reminded of George Orwell’s lessons in his book *1984*,” says Microsoft president Brad Smith. “The fundamental story was about a government that could see everything that everyone did and hear everything that everyone said all the time. Well, that didn’t come to pass in 1984, but if we’re not careful it could come to pass in 2024.”

It could be a
golden era
for humanity.